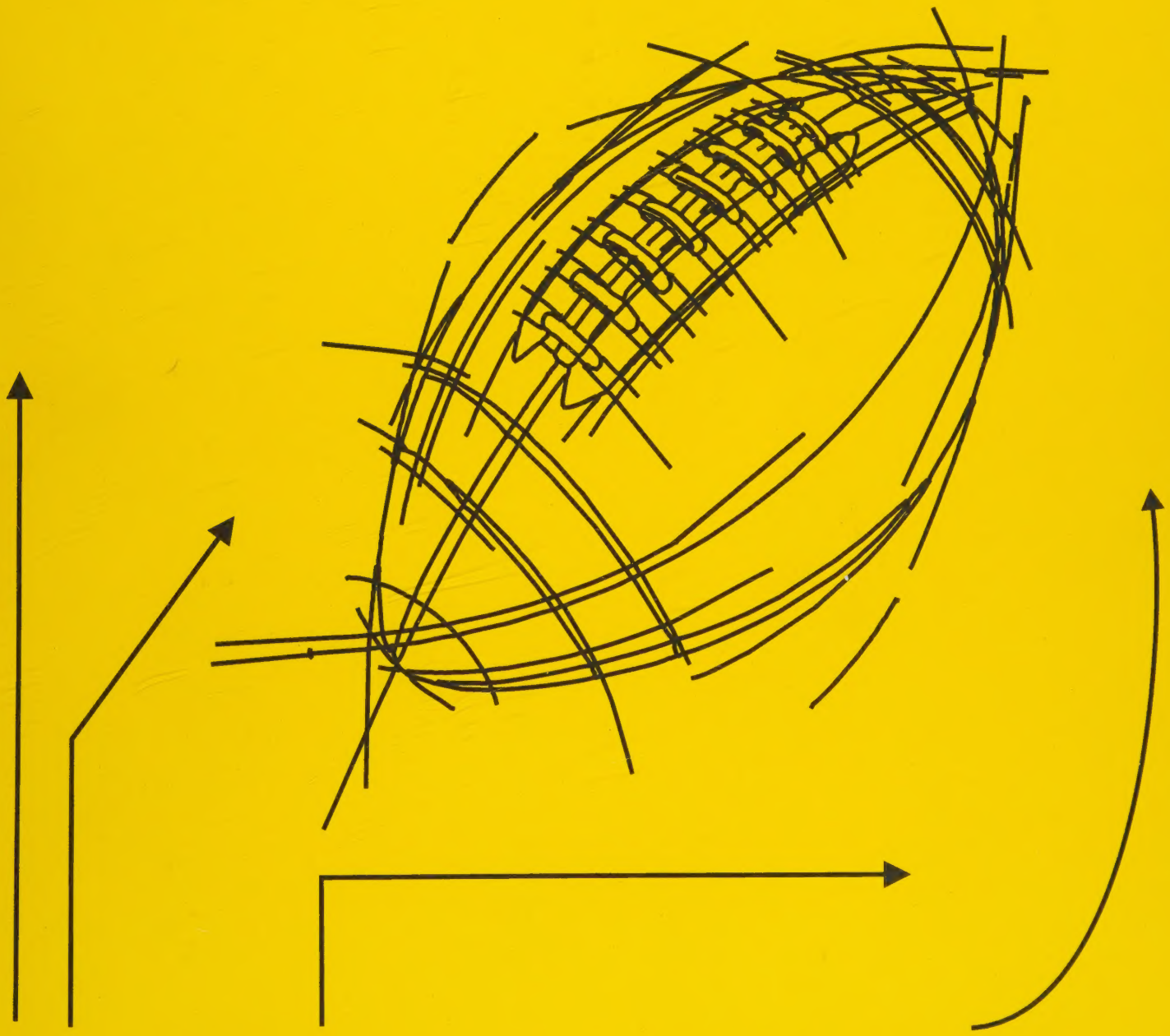
# DOMINATING YOUTH FLAG FOOTBALL



From the coaches of
FootballTimes.org

Coach M. Alo
Over 40 years of coaching experience

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# Dominating Youth Flag Football

**Coach M. Alo**

**CoachAlo.com**

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# DEDICATION

To all the amazing parents, grandparents, coaches, players, and friends of this great game of football!

**FootballTimes.org**

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# ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Thank you to our entire staff at Football Times and especially to Coach Alo for suggesting we turn this into a book. We have spent countless years educating players and coaches and providing resources to the public at no cost on our website. Our website and resources have primarily been dedicated to tackle football, with some flag football segments. But we found most of our free time was spent coaching youth flag football and most of the people we played against failed to recognize the difference between flag and tackle, and that you can't use the same plays and strategies. So, we decided to put this guide together to help others. We have spent the better part of 40 years dominating at every level, now you can too!

# Introduction

So, you've signed up to coach your son's flag football team, but have no idea where to start? Or maybe, you have coached before, but keep losing games or can't get the kids to run any successful plays on offense? Or you keep getting scored on? Or can never advance the ball?

Then this is the book for you! We hate seeing parent coaches fail or look lost or baffled, so we created this simple guide to help you get started.

We will discuss everything from understanding your kids' minds and how they process information to complex football offensive and defensive strategies that will help you win games and learn football. We will even discuss how to run practice and what to focus on every week during the season.

The target audience of this book is parent coaches of 7-10 year old flag football players. Of course, many of these concepts and plays can work at every level of flag football play, including adult leagues. But we have designed it primarily for coaching 7-10 year olds. In certain sections we will discuss how to adapt the plays and concept for older children in the 11-14 year old range, and even for college players and adult leagues.

Some of these concepts can also be used for youth tackle football and the plays can easily be adapted for tackle football. If you coach tackle football, swing by our website or Amazon.com and look for our tackle football book!

We will even give you access to our generic flag football playbook that you can download and send to the parents to have them practice the plays with their kids. Go to FootballTimes.org and click on Free Football Playbooks to grab all of our playbooks. And it's all free!

# Who are we?

We are the football coaches, writers, editors, and developers of FootballTimes.org. We've spent the last 40 years researching football, gathering playbooks, developing plays, explaining plays, reading every football book that's ever been written, and playing football. We've spent forty years as football coaches on the field with our team mates and later on the sidelines coaching every level of play.

We have found that certain things work very well in flag football that don't always translate well into tackle football. And certain concepts and plays that work well in tackle football, certainly don't translate into flag football. If you played tackle football growing up, which most of us have, you can't use those same practice techniques and plays in flag football. It's an entirely different ball game. But you will also find that many of the basic concepts and plays are quite similar. Be sure to grab our tackle football book too!

# Flag Football

Thirty years ago, there was really only tackle football. Flag football was unheard of, but it's grown in popularity in intramural sports on college campuses and in recreational adult leagues. Even medical schools now have intramural flag football. And because of all the concussion concerns, parents have stopped enrolling their children in tackle football and flag football popularity has risen tremendously.

Flag football teaches children incredible lessons in athletic agility as well as life lessons. Because of the explosive stop and start movements, kids will develop incredible coordination, agility, and burn a ton of calories, all while having loads of fun. They will also learn teamwork, discipline, leadership, and mental toughness. Football is the ultimate team sport and everyone must do their job in order for the team to succeed.

# Dominating Flag Football

In our years of coaching, we noticed a trend. Our teams would completely dominate the opponents. We would score 4-6 touchdowns per game, and not allow any. In many games, we

would not even allow the other team to advance the ball at all. Our teams would go all year and never have to punt. So much so, that we don't even practice punting. Ever. We would score on every possession, the opposing team would never score. Opponents would be losing yardage on every play and going backwards, while we, rarely if ever lost yardage. It was incredibly lopsided.

The other coaches would come up to us afterwards and ask us how we did it? What's the secret? What are you guys doing differently? We were always happy to share. It wasn't that we had superior talent. All the kids are similarly athletic and capable at this stage. Even games where our top two most athletic kids were missing, we would still win 4-1. It's all in the coaching! That's the big secret.

We keep it simple. We see other teams trying to run pro-formation, have 3 guys in the backfield, try very complex college and NFL plays, and they kept losing yards, fumbling, and going backwards. It's no fun to lose, even if it's just for fun and recreation. But you also have to put your kids in position to do well, to succeed, and ultimately to win. Remember, these are kids, they are not NFL players or college athletes. Keep it very, very simple. We can't stress that enough.

## Understanding Kids' Minds

Between the ages of 7-10, children's minds aren't developed enough to have that intrinsic football savvy like a wise old linebacker or free safety. They are single minded. Their mind can really only focus on one task at a time. Which is why we try to keep things as simple as possible. You'll notice that the majority of offensive plays are very simple misdirection plays that are all run out of one single formation. You'll also notice that the defensive formation we use is one single defensive alignment, with almost no variation. Keeping things this simple will help you and your kids succeed.

## No Endurance Training

We do not run a mile. We do not do gut busters. We don't climb hills. We do football stuff. We play games. Practice needs to be fun, not torture. There are plenty of things we do that build up their endurance, they are just formatted as fun football games and drills. If you torture the kids

in practice, they will hate the sport forever. That's the last thing we need right now. They should love practice and want to be there. It doesn't matter if you are a neurosurgeon by day, you can be the most fun parent ever at practice. You need to get down and dirty with them and just have a blast.

## Sprinting

You will have to teach kids how to sprint and how to run fast. Most kids have never been taught the proper form on how to run fast. They run the plays while jogging and think that is good enough. You have to show them the proper form, with arms at 90 degrees, pumping their arms back and forth, with their hands traveling from up by their lips, down to their hips. We coach, from "lips to hips". Also, teach them how to do this while running with the football in the "cone hold" position, tucked tight to the body. We time their 20 or 40 yard dash times before and after to show them the improvement that proper form will make.

## Cone Hold

We teach the kids to hold the ball with their fingers over the cone of the ball, so that their fingers cover the cone and fold over to the other side. It's very hard to knock the ball out when it's "coned" and held tight to the body. We demonstrate this by holding the ball out in one hand and have them knock it out of the coach's hand and see how easy it is to knock out. Then we cone it and tuck it in tight, they punch at it and can't knock it out.

## No Drills

We do not do any mindless drills that are unrelated to football. We do not have them jumping through tires on the ground. We do not make them shuttle through cones. We don't make them do monkey bars. We do not have them high step laterally through ladders on the ground. We do fun football drills and games that accomplish the same things and teach the same agility and skills. It needs to be fun. Endless drills prove that you are a good drill sergeant, not a good coach. Anyone can be a strict drill sergeant. You need to be a fun parent coach. We will get into the details of our practice games and drills in a later chapter.

Once they get older, you can start doing conditioning drills. But for most kids ages 5 through 8 years old, you need to just make it fun. When they are 9 or older, you can start incorporating

pure conditioning drills, but keep them fun. They should look forward to it. The defensive flag pulling drill we describe at the end is a great one that also conditions them.

## Three Rules

In flag football, we teach the kids three basic rules. As long as they follow these three rules, we will be happy and will win a lot of games.

1. You must pull flags
2. You can't go out of bounds
3. Don't stop till you hear a whistle

We will expand on these concepts and why they are so crucial to our success.

## Pulling Flags

The most important thing in flag football is defense. You have to pull flags. That's the only thing we really practice on defense. We just pull flags. We pull them in very fun and very creative ways. In the practice drills section we show you the one single best flag pulling drill. If you can't pull flags, you aren't going to win many games.

Do you know how hard it is to pull a flag? Find a 5 year old, have them wear flags, and have them run around a bunch of NFL players, and just see how hard it is to pull the flag. It's very hard. So when given the choice of whether to cut or just run straight towards an opposing player, we tell them to run straight, because the likelihood that they will actually pull your flag is very, very low. No dancing. You aren't Barry Sanders. We don't want them to fear running straight at people and absolutely do not want them running backward away from opposing players. We practice running with flags and flag pulling in a very fun game/drill that you can read about later.

# Don't Go Out of Bounds

We can't stress this enough. There is absolutely no reason in flag football, or any level of football, to go out of bounds. Why give the other team the easy out? They aren't going to tackle you if you cut back inside. We teach our kids that they absolutely can not go out of bounds. When running toward the sideline or down the sideline, and you are faced with a player coming at you, cut back inside. Don't give them the easy down. Make them work for that flag pull. It's incredibly hard to pull a flag. Especially, with someone running at you full speed ahead. The flag pulling game we play teaches them to stay in bounds at all costs.

When running back Terrell Davis was a rookie in Denver playing for the Denver Broncos, he would occasionally step out of bounds on wide running plays. The entire team gasped and was shocked that he did that. Veteran wide receiver Rod Smith walked over to Davis and said, "Wide receivers and running backs don't step out of bounds here in Denver. Ever." The rest is history. Davis would never willingly step out of bounds again. He would go on to rush for an NFL record-breaking 2476 yards in the 1998 season (including playoffs). Because he stayed in bounds.

Just stay in bounds and get those extra yards. They aren't going to get your flag nor tackle you.

# Don't stop till you hear a whistle

It's very hard to know if your flag was pulled. We teach the kids to keep running until you hear a whistle. The referee will let you know if your flag was pulled. Don't look down at your flags, don't try to see if they pulled it, just run as fast as you can. If your flag was pulled, the referee will let you know. That's one less thing to think about.

# Stand Up and Raise your Hand

If you pull an opposing players flag, stay where you are and stand up with the flag held high. Don't start walking. Most kid's initial reaction is to start walking toward the referee. This is bad. Why? Because most of the time you are walking forward and giving the opposing team extra yards. Just freeze as soon as you have a flag in your hands. The referee will see where you

are and mark the player down there. This is huge and we harp on it a lot. Don't give the opponents extra yards.

## Stop dancing and juking

Every team has that one kid that starts running to the right, sees a bunch of defenders, cuts back to the left, sees more defenders, goes back right, takes jump step, then tries to run again, and you've lost ten yards before they finally get him. It's very hard to break this tendency. The kids think that if there are defenders in front of them, that they will get their flags no matter what. It's very hard to pull flags, and we keep stressing this and showing them how hard it is. We coach them to just run past and in between defenders and see if they can pull their flags. It's a challenge. If your quarterback keeps juking and running backwards, it's time to change to a quarterback that will run straight ahead and not cutback. We've had to do that a few times. Put in a kid that will run the intended play and run between defenders and not be afraid to just run and see if they can get his flag.

One drill we've used to break this tendency is to line up 3-4 defenders on one side standing in a row. Have the ball snapped to the QB, and then have him accelerate as fast as he can through them and see if anyone actually pulls the flag. After he makes it through 9 times out of 10, he will realize that you just have to run between them and not worry about it.

## Defense First, Defense Always

If you can't pull flags and play defense, you are going to struggle to get wins. We always prioritize defense. We don't spend a lot of time in practice on defense, but we prioritize it in other ways.

We made sure that the fastest kids were on the field on defense. No compromise. If you can't run around, you won't be in on defense. It's that simple. No obese kids on defense in flag football! The kids will slip fall, make mistakes, and fall for misdirection plays. They need to be able to recover quickly. You have to be fast. There are usually one or two kids that are incredible athletes on each team, make sure they are in on defense. The other team will also have one or two of those, and they will be playing offense. So get your athletes in on defense

and put them in position to create plays. We usually put them in at linebacker and safety and tried to funnel everything to them. More on this later.

## Offensive Strategy

Our offensive strategy was pretty simple and very effective. In the beginning, we taught the kids one single offensive formation. Everything was run out of that formation. So no matter who we put in, they knew where to go. We rarely deviated. As the kids got older and they mastered that one offensive formation, we would change it up a bit, mainly because the other teams caught on to what we were doing.

We introduced one new play per week. The first week we made sure we had two simple plays to start, but after that, we would introduce one new play per week. We would practice running it in both directions.

We spend most of our practice time on offense. We would demonstrate the plays, and then have every kid run them. We didn't want any of the kids to feel left out, it is recreational flag football, and we are not competing for a $20,000 prize. During the games, when we are winning 4-0, we would take out all of our best offensive players and put in the kids that aren't as good or as fast, and we would still end up winning 6-0. That's how easy our plays and playbooks were. Anyone can run them. Like we say, the kids aren't all that different in terms of talent, it's just a matter of what you are asking them to do. If it's simple, any kid can do it.

## Everyone Practices Everything

In practice, we have every kid play every position. So at a moment's notice, we can change them around in the game. Too many times we've seen other teams have one designated quarterback, and if he's sick or gets injured, or just has a temper tantrum, the other team is toast. That will never happen to our teams. Even the smallest, or slowest, or biggest players on our team practice all of our offensive plays and can run them if necessary. And it's a lot of fun for them. They all love to be quarterback, and we can't have all 17 kids play quarterback during the games, we definitely can get them to be quarterback in practice and they love it. We try to simulate game like scenarios in practice, so it all seems very real.

## Game Simulation

In practice, we try to simulate game situations. We have limited players, so we don't use a full offensive line or a full defense, but we try to put in enough players to make it challenging. We have just the snapper snap it back to the quarterback and then the wide receivers or tight ends running the play. On defense we keep in a linebacker, a nose tackle to rush the quarterback, and a few cornerbacks. This helps it feel more real and it's fun. When we are first teaching the plays, we don't do this. When we first demonstrate each offensive play, the coaches demonstrate it, or if you are by yourself, use one or two players to help you demonstrate. Keep making them do it till they master it. Have every single kid practice it so that they all understand it.

## Limit Ball Exchanges

Statistically, all mistakes in youth flag football happen on ball exchanges. That's any time the ball is being transferred from one player to another player, either via hand off or through the air. We try to limit the number of ball exchanges to limit the amount of mistakes. If your league rules don't require you to snap the ball back and it can start in the quarterback's hands, that's even better. But most leagues require a snap off the ground and through the air. They usually require it to be snapped either through the legs, or a sideways snap of the ball back to the quarterback.

All of our plays are designed with just one or two ball exchanges. The ball being snapped back to the quarterback is the first ball exchange. If he runs with it, there are no other exchanges. Most of our plays are the quarterback running with the ball. If he hands it off or throws it, that's the second ball exchange. We try to limit those plays and not use them during games unless we are winning by a comfortable margin or really need that 20 yard first down play. More on this in our plays section.

The biggest mistake teams make is asking the players to do too many ball exchanges. Too many times we've seen coaches trying to make their kids do the impossible. The ball ends up on the ground, they fumble the snap, fumble the handoff, or they throw interceptions. You have to limit these plays to tip the odds in your favor. There is no reason to run complex plays that

require 5 ball exchanges in the backfield. Just stop. Simple plays. One or two ball exchanges max. You'll do very well.

## Slow developing plays

We also try to eliminate slow developing plays. By the time the ball makes it back to the quarterback, the defensive players have already made it to the backfield. You can't have three fake handoffs, and then a screen pass. You will be annihilated. In fact, you shouldn't waste any extra players in the backfield. You are using up players that could be blockers, and are taking them out of the play. See the next section.

## No Running Backs

There is no role for running backs in flag football. Period. There is absolutely no reason why more than one player needs to start behind the line of scrimmage. Putting a running back in the backfield with the quarterback, eliminates both players from the offensive play. You will be playing two players short. This helps the defense. If you want to do a running play, have your quarterback run the ball. If you quarterback is the runner and the passer, it will be even more confusing to the defense.

The only reason that you need two separate players to play running back and quarterback in high school, college, or the pros is because the fastest runner is no longer also the best thrower. You need two separate players to do these highly specialized skills. There are very few really good quarterbacks in high school, and even fewer of them can actually run a sub 4.6 forty yard dash. So you will need two different players in more advanced types of football. See the articles on our website for more on this: FootballTimes.org.

At any level of flag football play, you do not need highly specialized players that can only do one thing. Any wide receiver can also play quarterback, can also run, can snap the ball, and can also catch the ball. Whether they are 7-10 years old or in college intramurals, there is no reason to use up players in the backfield when they can be blocking for runs up field or running passing routes to push the defense away.

The entire concept behind Urban Meyer's Spread Option Offense was to make the quarterback the runner, so that the offense is playing 10 vs 11 ball. The quarterback can't block for himself, so he is out of the numbers game. You want to tip the number's game in your favor. If you put a running back in the backfield, now you are playing 9 vs 11 and you have less of a chance to succeed. It's all about tipping the odds in your favor. See our Spread Option Offense articles on our website: FootballTimes.org.

At the youth flag football level, all of the kids' skill sets and athletic abilities are very similar. Almost any kid can run any play. Especially, the very simple plays we have designed for them. So you do not need highly specialized players. You just need them to run the plays correctly. There may be one or two kids who are outstanding athletes, but the rest can run the plays just as well.

## Playmakers

Like Urban Meyer, we want to get the ball into the playmaker's hands. Every team will have one or two kids that are much faster, much more agile, much bigger than the other kids. We try to get the ball into their hands frequently. You can move your fastest player around, he does not always have to be playing quarterback. All of our plays are designed so that one player ultimately ends up with the ball. On quarterback sneak plays, put that player in at quarterback. On end arounds, have him be the wide receiver. On passing plays, make sure he is the receiver that ends up catching it. It's pretty simple.

## What if you don't have any Playmakers?

What if none of your kids is an outstanding athlete and they are all very similar in skill level? This is the perfect scenario that we wrote this book for. We want to take a bunch of mediocre kids and turn them into a winning football team. All of our plays and philosophies can be run properly with very non athletic players as well. You don't need speed or agility, you need to be in the right place to make the play. We try to make sure they are in good position and understand their role on offense or defense.

# Recreational

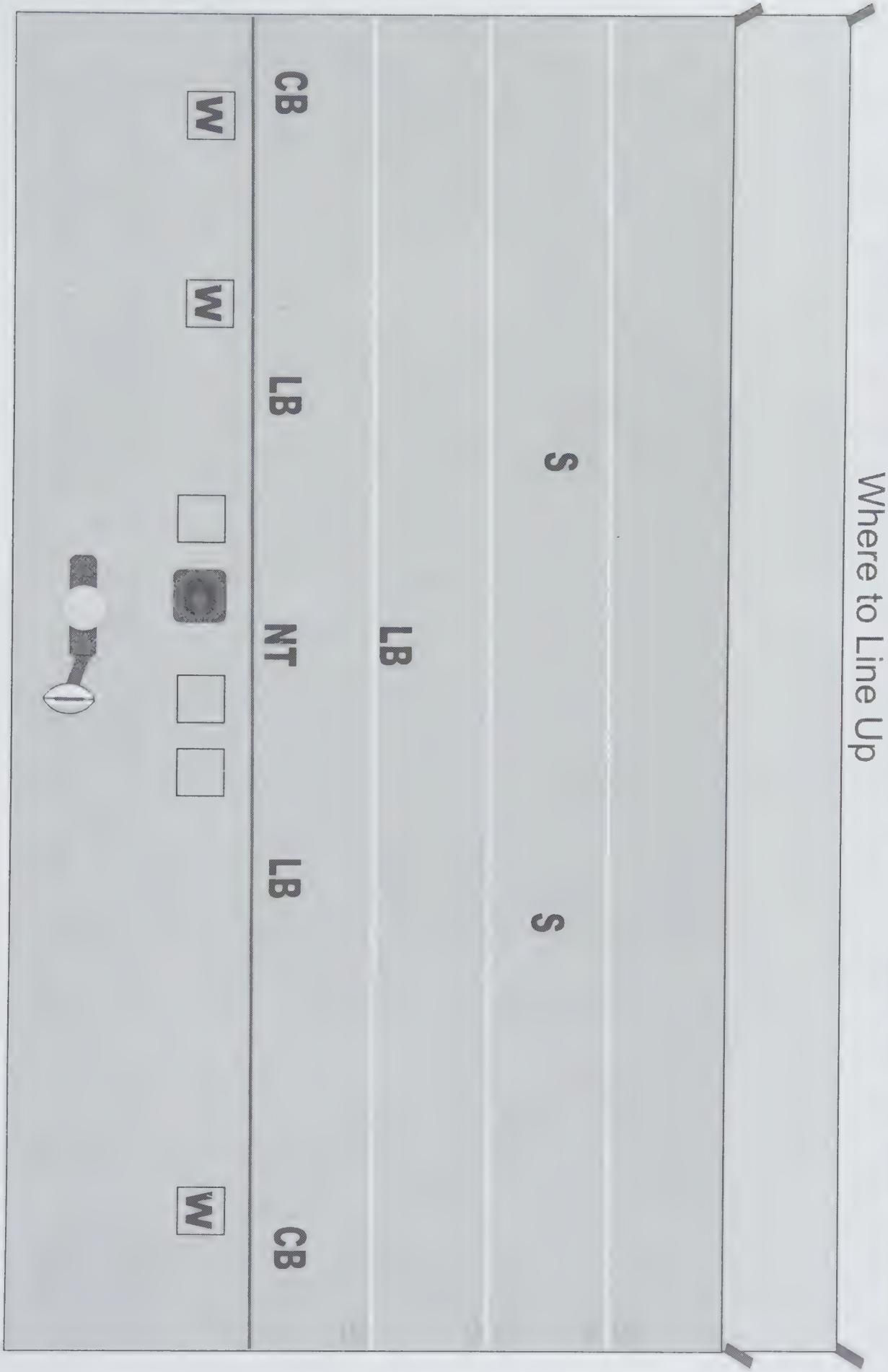
It is recreational flag football. So make sure the kids feel like they are having fun. You do not need to only use your playmakers. Show that you can win with the average kids, which you can, and you will. Don't make the other kids feel like you favor getting the ball to just the most athletic kids. If you have a comfortable lead, have all the other kids run the plays. They will be happy. Imagine if Johnny has never played quarterback, you are on the one yard line, you put Johnny in at quarterback and call a quarterback sneak and he scores? Memory of a lifetime for him and his parents. Especially, if it was unexpected. Have fun and find creative ways of having even more fun.

# Defense

Our defensive philosophy is to always have the players facing the play. They never turn their backs on the play and chase wide receivers down field. Just stand your ground and watch the backfield. The ball is rarely thrown, and if it is, we usually intercept it. It's your basic cover 2 zone defense. Everyone has a square or area that they cover and they stay there watching the play. Never turn your back on the play!

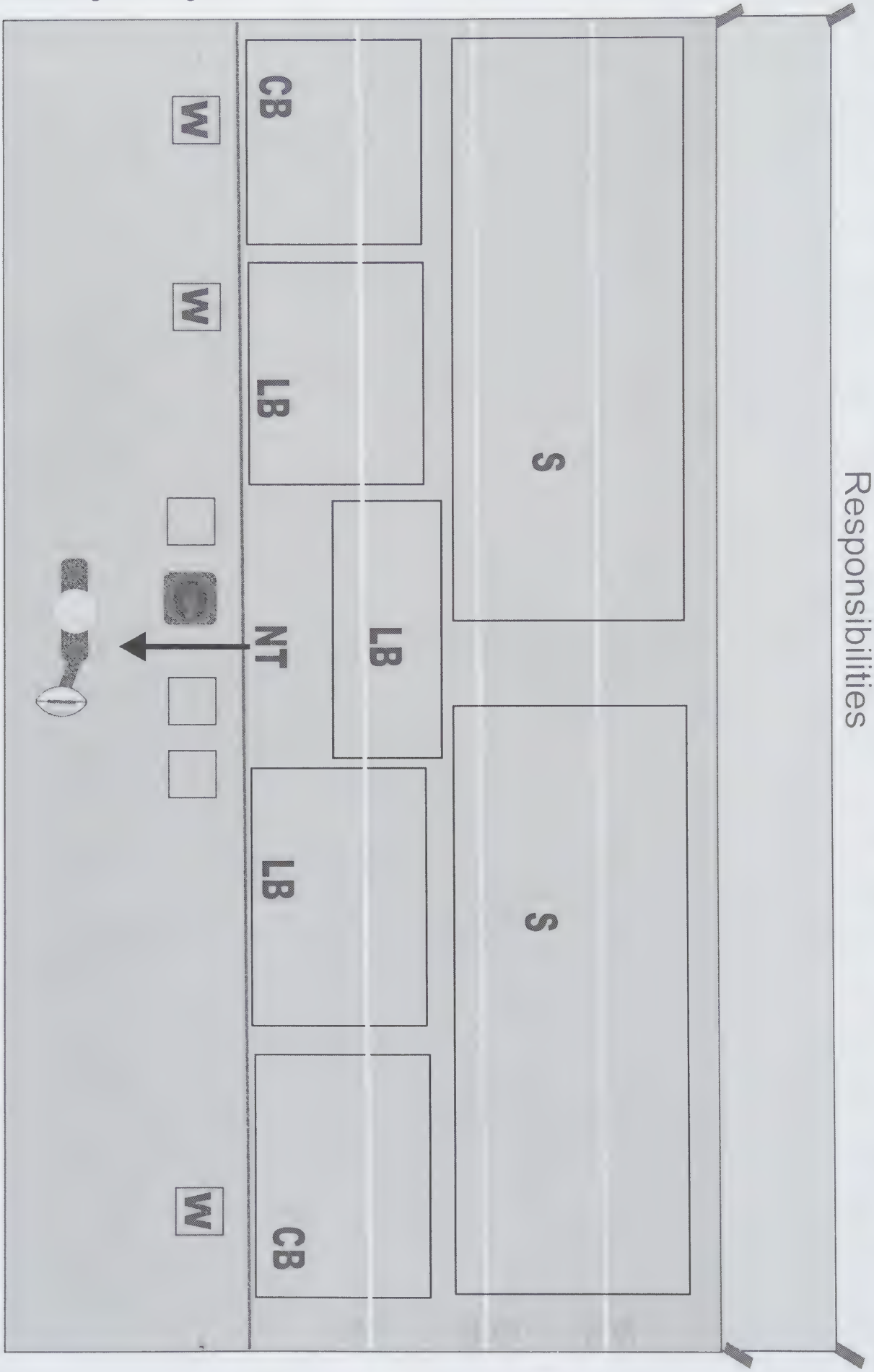
# ZONE DEFENSE

## Where to Line Up



# ZONE DEFENSE

## Responsibilities



This is our defensive alignment. One single formation. We don't deviate. We have one rusher, which we usually call the nose tackle. We have two cornerbacks that seal the edge. We usually have two safeties in case they pass or the runner gets beyond the first wave of defenders. We have two outside linebackers lined up wide on either side of the nose tackle to stop runs (sort of like nickel cornerbacks). And we have one middle linebacker to roam around behind the nose tackle and pick up any runs or short passes. You might have to adjust these numbers depending on how many players can be on the field. If it's 7 on 7, we drop one safety, because the likelihood for a successful pass play is very low. Play the odds.

The biggest key though is that they are all looking at the backfield at all times. No one turns to chase wide receivers. Even in college intramurals, this is the formation that we use and that we coach. It's a cover 2 formation with zone underneath. Or "All Zone" as we call it. See our website for more details on Zone Defense for Flag Football: FootballTimes.org

## Assignment Football

We play assignment football. A good disciplined team, that stays in their zone, or plays their role correctly will always beat a team with better athletes. This rule almost never fails. As long as everyone does their job, you will be in a better position to win. Too many times you see teams allowing a superior athlete to just roam freely and play freestyle. That may work for a while, but it won't help the player develop. Too many times we seem them overcommit or overrun the play. We love coaching offense against these undisciplined players.

## Nose Tackle

Choose a smaller and faster kid for this role. The nose tackle lines up to either side of the snapper and rushes the quarterback. In most flag football rules, he can rush on every play. His job is to get to the quarterback's flag as fast as possible. He chases him back and forth and tries to get it. If the opposite team has 3-4 blockers up front, he can just line up wider and rush in. They won't even see him coming. He can pretend he is guarding a wide receiver. Kids at this age are not that smart, and it even works with high school and college level play.

## Outside Linebackers

These guys line up on the outside of the offensive line or on the interior of the wide receivers. Their job is to wait and see what happens. Read and react. If there are handoffs going on or if the quarterback starts to run in either direction, they hold their positions and get the flags. If handoffs occur in the backfield, we coach them to not just rush in too quickly and to try and hold their ground due to reverses and end arounds. It's very easy to fool 8 year olds with end arounds, so we want them to stay until the play has fully developed.

If it looks like an obvious pass they can back peddle slightly, but never turn their back on the play until the ball is in the air.

## Middle Linebacker

This should be one of your faster kids with good instinctual play and savvy. He is to line up right behind the nose tackle, just 3 yards off the line of scrimmage. No further than that. His job is to roam behind the nose tackle. Try to hold his ground as long as possible and then go after the play once it's developed fully. Don't over commit to one side because there are a lot of reverses. Well, there might not be a lot of reverses, but when they do occur, they work very well because the kids don't see it until it's too late.

If it's a short pass, he will be there for the flag pull, interception, or tip. If it is over his head, he can quickly get to the play and pull the flag. The idea is to eliminate short, easy plays and force them to complete very difficult passing plays. The safeties will be back there too, so it should be covered.

## Cornerbacks

The role of the cornerback is to stand his ground and not allow a runner to get outside of him or around him to the sideline. If a running play is coming to his side, his job is to back up to the sideline and not allow the runner to get around him to the outside. If that happens, it's highly

likely that the other team will gain a lot of yards or score a long touchdown. He has to back up to the sideline and protect it forcing the runner to cut back inside to where we have a lot of help. The other players can then pull the flag. Force the runner back inside! We tell our cornerbacks not to worry about pulling the flag, because instinctively they all want to. But rather, that they will not be the one pulling the flag, but forcing them back towards our other players that will pull the flag.

The cornerbacks should line up 3 yards off the line of scrimmage and force the wide receiver outside. It's nearly impossible for a youth quarterback to throw accurately that far downfield and that far outside.

The cornerback will probably not make the tackle on a sweep to his side. His job is to protect the sideline and allow others to make the tackle. Assignment football always beats better athletes.

## Safeties

Their job is to sit back and watch the play. They are usually 7-8 yards off the line of scrimmage. They don't need to be too deep. No one at this age is going to throw a 30 yard bomb. They watch to see what the play is, then react quickly to pull the flag if the runner gets past the first line of defense. We don't want them to overcommit and run in right away if it's a running play. We want them to slowly shift to the side the runner is going to and then wait to see if the other guys pull the flag. Also, they need to slow down because of the possible reverses. While other teams don't run reverses too often, when they do, it's usually very successful. We need to prevent those plays. Our safeties basically function as deeper linebackers.

If it's a passing play, they just watch it develop then run up and defend, tip, or intercept.

## How do we coach defense?

We show them the alignment by putting a kid in each position. Then we have them all come together and walk with us from position to position. We explain everything about each position from the above sections. We start at nose tackle and explain the job. Then walk over to the

outside linebackers and explain each role and the assignments. We do this with each position. The hardest one to explain is cornerback, so we spend quite some time explaining that and demonstrating it. Instinctively they all want to run in and pull the flag, but we teach them that this is not what we want. It's hard for them to grasp that concept.

When we are practicing offensive plays with a skeleton crew, we also put players in on defense to show them their assignments and coach them up on what to do or what they should have done. You'll find that even though we are practicing a play and the defense knows which play we are running, they will still be fooled by it. That's how easy it is to fool 8 year olds with misdirection plays.

Sometimes we line up our entire starting defense, and one of our coaches plays against them by himself. He has the ball, says "hike" and starts running left. We try to see that they all know their assignments. Then the next play, he starts out running left and cuts back right. We watch to see if they over committed to the left. Then he takes the snap and throws it up to the safety on the right, then another run, then throw it to the other safety. The whole idea is to keep them guessing and see if they break their alignment or get out of position.

We even coach them on the field during the games. Especially the cornerbacks. We remind them to not let anyone around them to the sideline and that they have to force everyone back inside to where all the help is. They have to hold the line.

We don't spend very much time practicing defense after we explain it all. We spend 90% of our time on offense each week and having fun. They figure out the defense while we practice offense when we put some players in on defense to defend the play to get some semblance of a real game scenario. We stress assignment. Assignment football always beats better athletes.

We spend the last 15 minutes of each practice playing a flag pulling game that also builds endurance, agility, and re enforces that they are not allowed to step out of bounds. More on that later. Our practices run from 5:30-7:00pm, but after the first few, we could easily have condensed them into just 1 hour practices. In your first week before the season starts, you might want to have two practices, so the kids can have a few nice plays to run and understand the defense.

# Offensive plays

In the next section we will be going through all of our offensive plays. We introduced 3 plays in the practices leading up to the first game, then added one play per week.

On the plays pages, the yard markers denote how far away from the line of scrimmage each consecutive line is. It does not show hos close you are to the goal line. This is to teach the players how far to run each route in relation to the line of scrimmage.

# Key:

A dark arrow line denotes the path a player is running.

A dotted line denotes the path of the ball when it's handed off or passed.

A T line denotes the path a player takes to block another player.

A shaded area denotes the area of defense that the encircled player is responsible for.

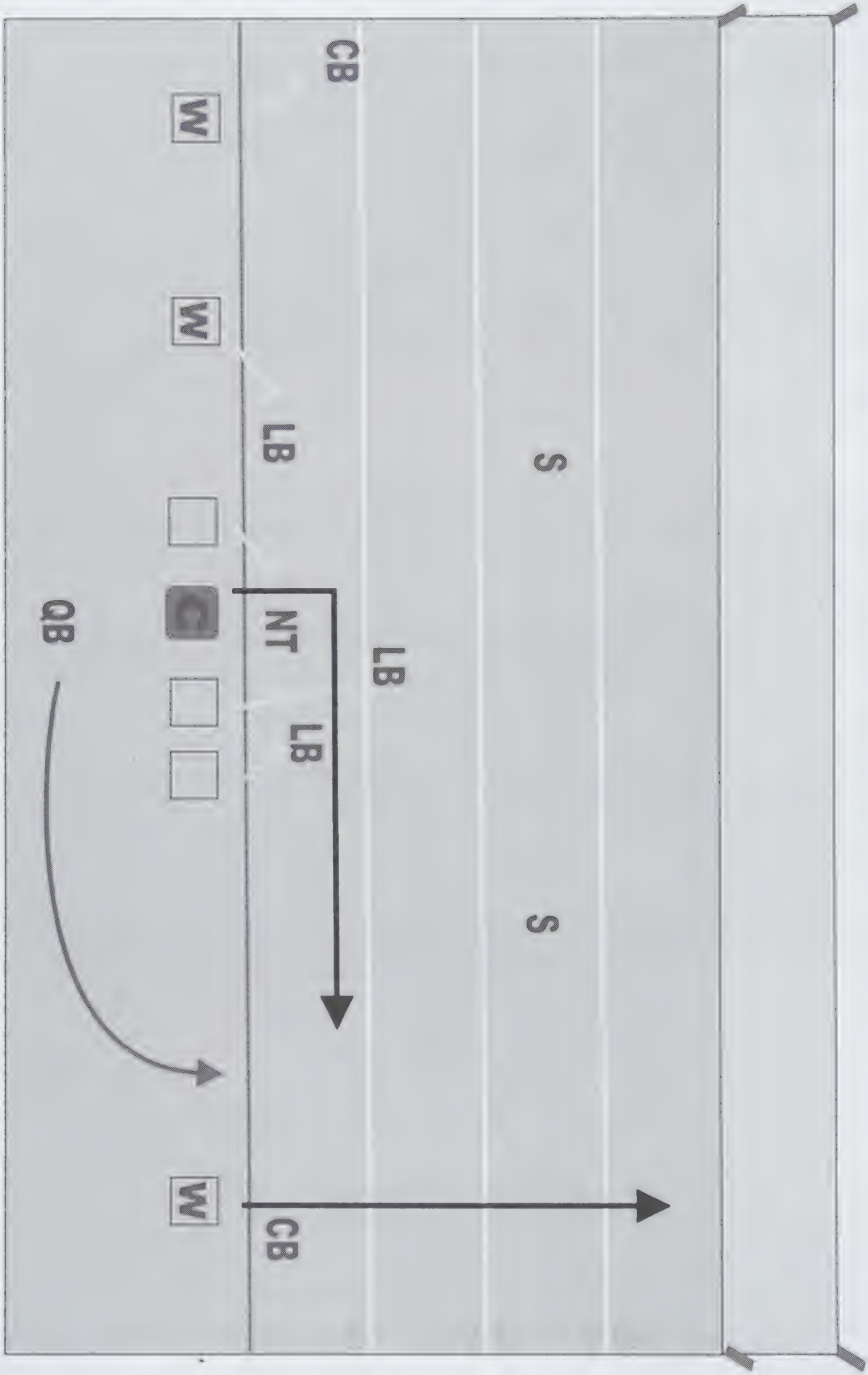
## On Defense:

NT- Nose Tackle
LB- Linebacker
CB-Cornerback
S- Safety

## On Offense:

W- Wide Receiver
QB- Quarterback
C- Center (the snapper)
☐- Offensive Line

# QB SWEEP

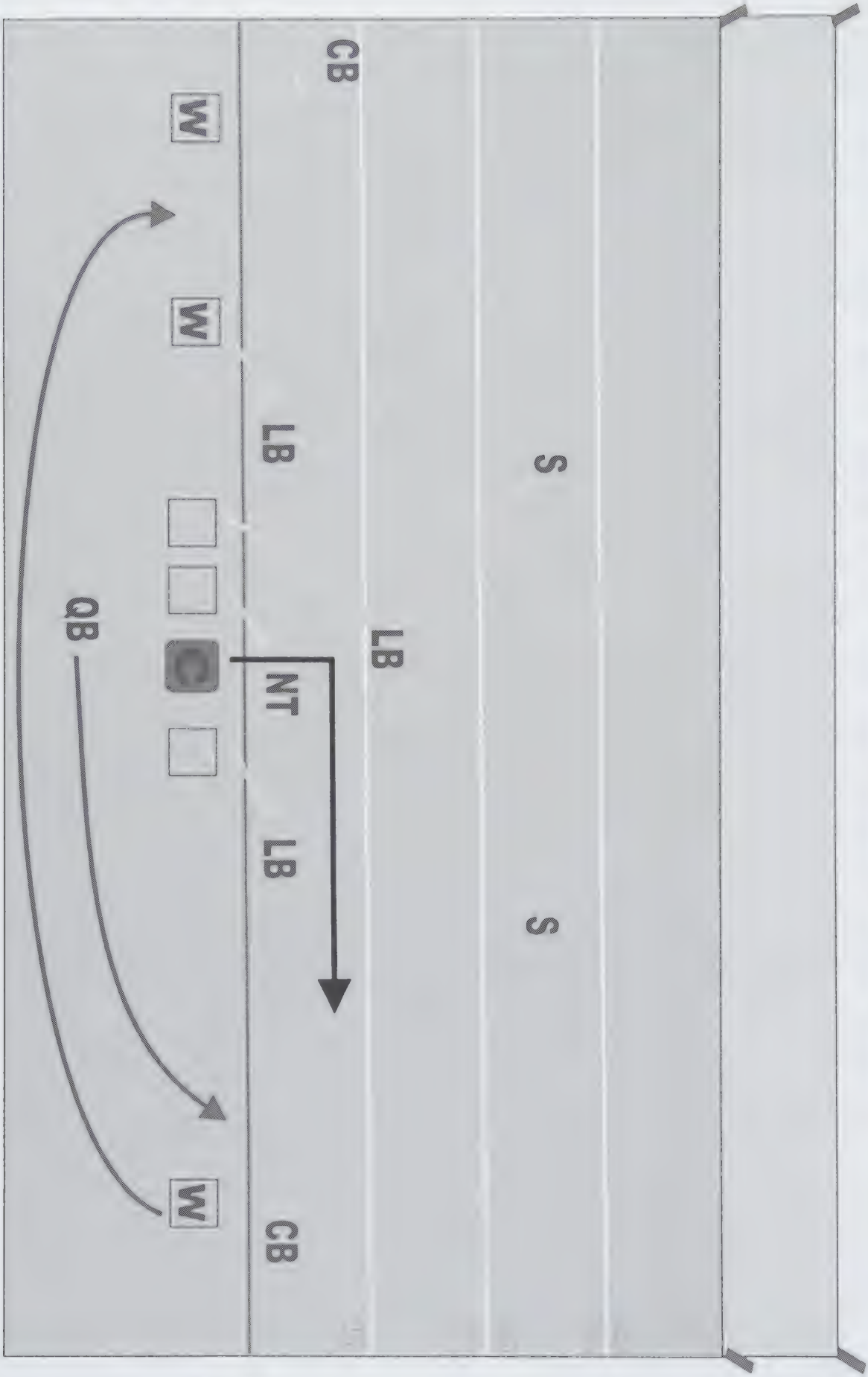


# Quarterback Sweep

This is our most basic play. The quarterback gets the ball and runs to right. We can also reverse it and have him run it to the left. This play will get you a lot of easy yards.

## Notes:

# END AROUND



# End Around

The next play we run right after the quarterback sweep, is usually the end around. The defense will think it's the same play again and they will all overcommit to the right. The wide receiver that gets the ball going the other way will get a lot of yards, maybe even a touchdown.

# Notes:

# Fake END AROUND

# Fake End Around

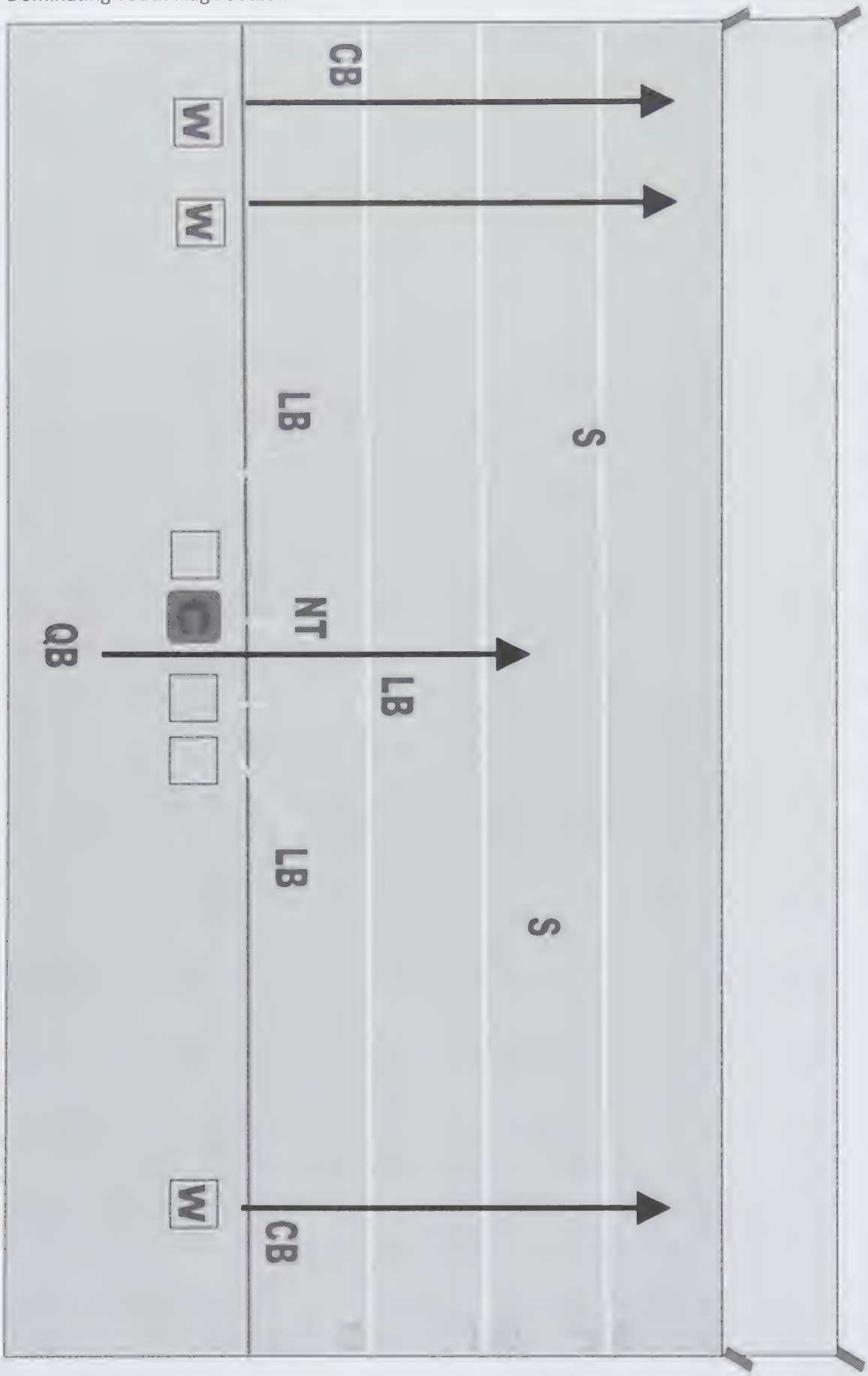
The play we run right after the end around is always the fake end around. The defenders think we are doing the same thing again, and will bite on the fake, meanwhile the quarterback continues to run down the right sideline to the end zone.

# Magical Trifecta

The three plays we just discussed should be run in that exact order. Each play sets up the next play. You are guaranteed to score a touchdown on the third play! But sometimes you end up scoring on the second or first play. It just depends on how the defense reacts. But this Magical Trifecta sets up the defense perfectly to fall flat on their faces. The first play gets the defense flowing to the right. The second play gets them flowing to the right and then the End Around takes it back left. The very next play, the defense is alert and bites on the Fake End Around and your quarterback is running free for an 80 yard touchdown. Make sure your quarterback is agile and fast. The most athletic kid on the team should be the quarterback. The second most athletic kid is the End Around wide receiver.

# Notes:

# QB SNEAK



# Quarterback Sneak

This play is quite useful for getting those short yards for a first down or a touchdown. A lot of times the quarterback can break it and run for a touchdown, because after he passes that first wave of defenders, there's usually a lot of empty space. One way we modify this is leave only the quarterback and the snapper in the middle and clear out everyone else. We put everyone else way on the periphery of the sidelines. We give the defense time to adjust and clear out their defenders, then we run it with the quarterback following the snapper or going to either side.

# Freeze Play

From the same formation, you can do a play called the freeze play to force the defense to encroach and get a free 5 yards. You call freeze in the huddle and remind all the players that they are all supposed to freeze and not move no matter what. The quarterback goes through his normal routine and says, "Ready, Set... Hike" as loud and as forcefully as possible. The defensive players will all jump offsides and get a penalty. It's important that the snapper not move the ball and not snap it either. Everyone has to freeze.

What if the freeze play doesn't cause a penalty and the defense doesn't move? You have to have a back up plan. The snapper waits a second and snaps the ball back to the quarterback without anyone saying anything. This is called a silent snap. The quarterback and lineman all run forward and run the quarterback sneak play and try to get as many yards as possible.

# Notes:

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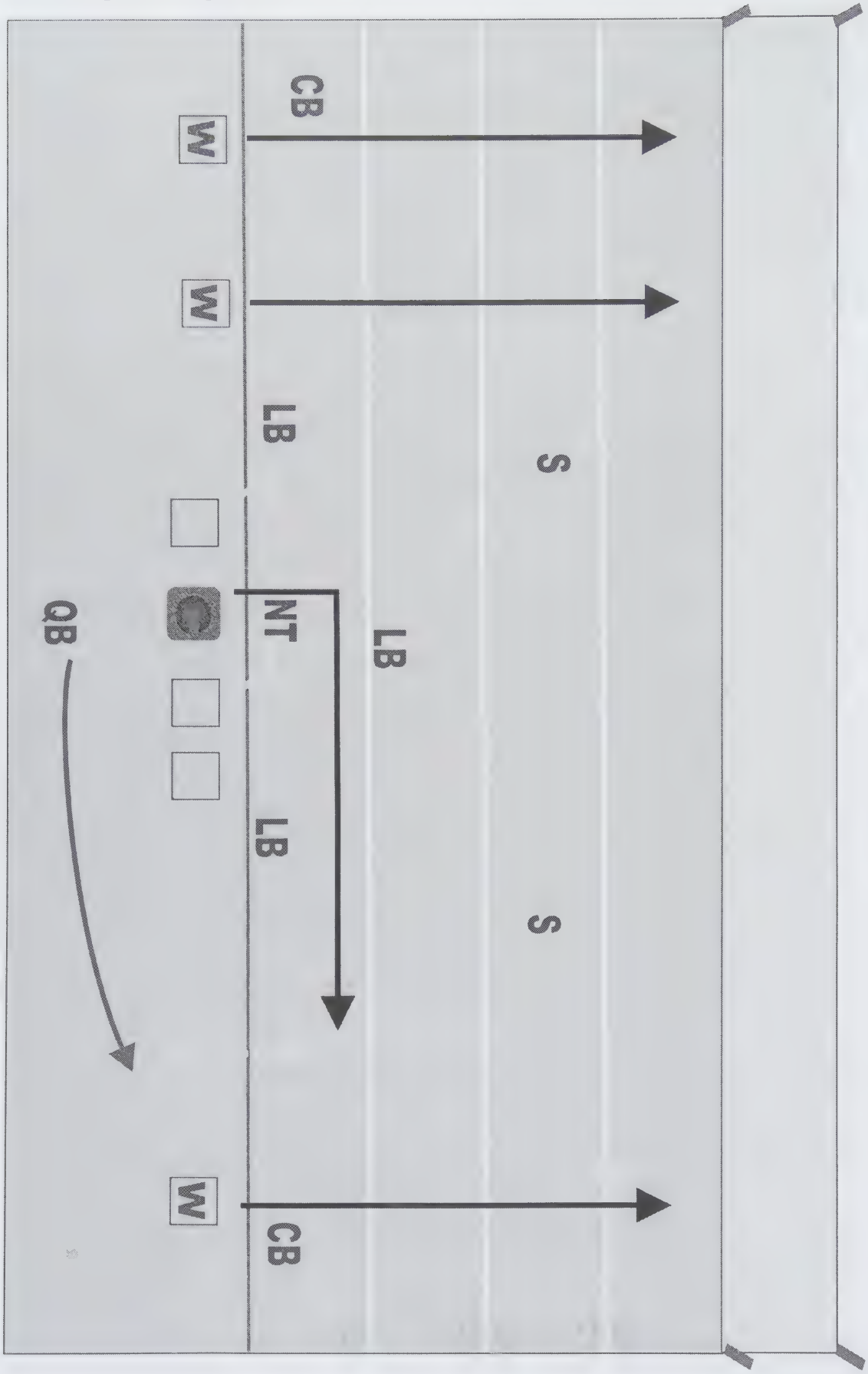
_____

# DRAG

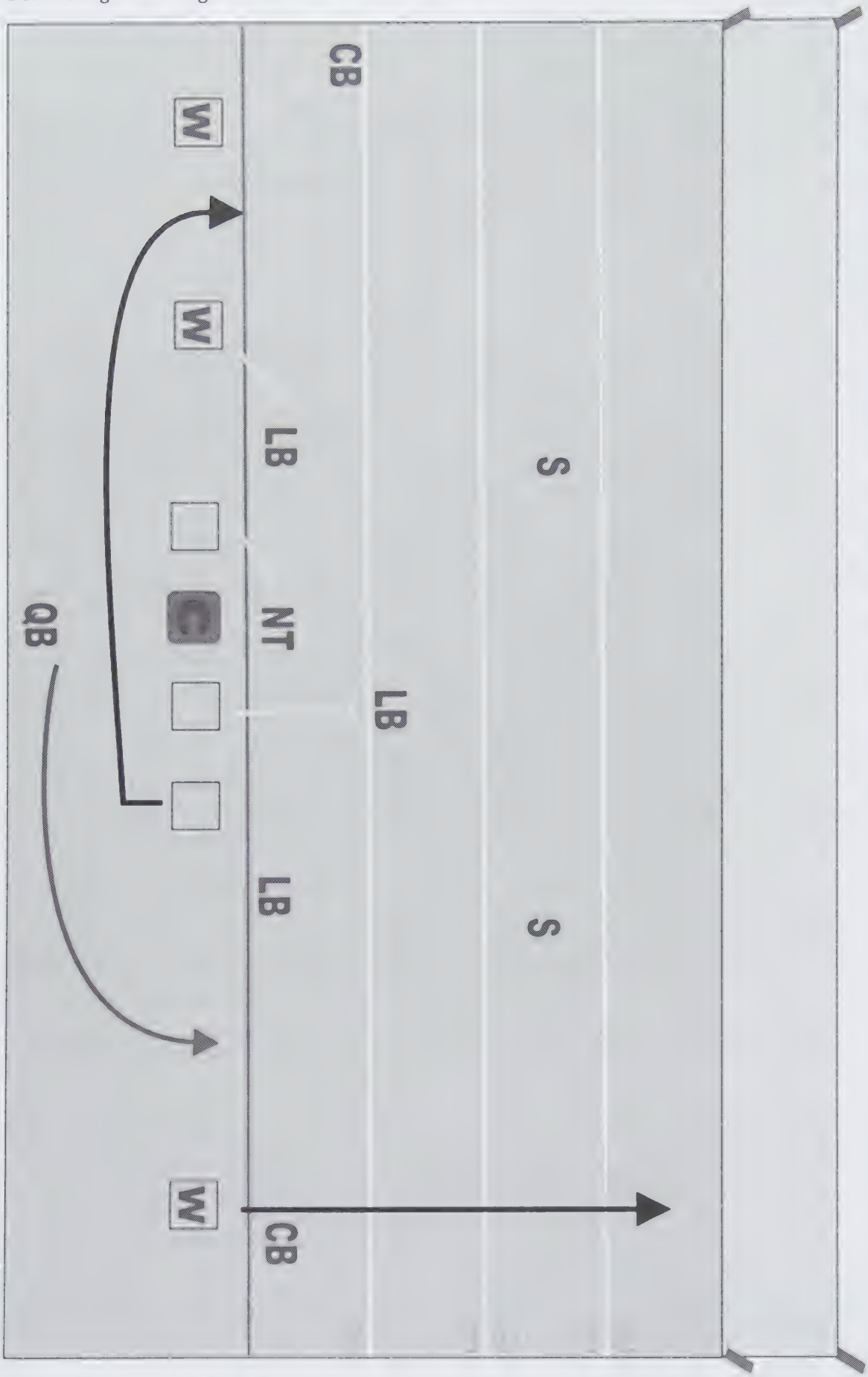


# Drag

This is the one pass play that we use when we need chunks of yardage or just for fun. We usually run it right after a quarterback sweep. The defenders see the quarterback running to the right again, they all come down to pull his flag and leave the wide receiver open or the tight end open. He will pass it if the defense all comes down on him. He will keep it and run if they don't bite and have their backs turned chasing the wide receivers down the field. The coach is usually standing in the backfield and can yell "just run it" to get him to just run if it looks wide open for a run. It's hard to younger kids to run a "Run Pass Option", but around 5th grade or higher, they should be able to do this. Adults can run this quite easily.

# Notes:

# TE SWEEP



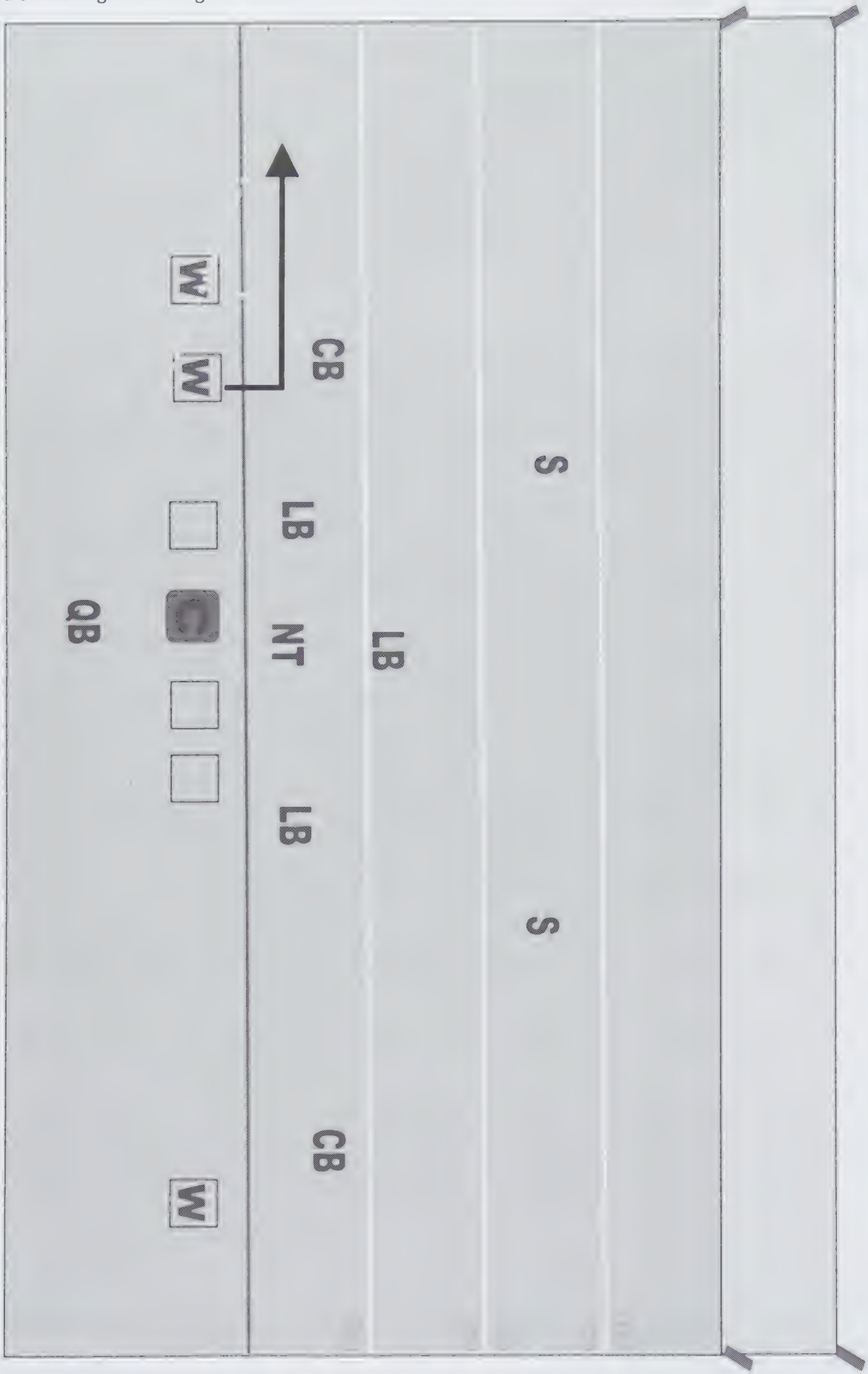
# TE Sweep

The TE sweep is a fun play. The quarterback gets the snap and hands it off inside of himself to a Tight End that drops back and crosses in front of him. The quarterback then runs it out to the other side pretending to have the ball. It happens quickly and defenders have no idea what is going on.

You can even run this with no QB in the back field, he can line up to the side of the single WR. The defense will be confused and wonder what is going on. We give them enough time to realize there is no quarterback. Then the Tight End comes in motion and gets a direct snap. The coach can say something like "John, you are on the wrong side" to initiate the play and give the defense the false pretense that nothing is going on other than John moving to the correct side. It may not work well, because the defense will see the TE moving and already be alerted to that and may figure it out quickly. When we ran it with no QB, we would just get a few fun yards. But when you run it with the QB sweeping to the other side, we did much better. And you can always fake it and the QB keeps the ball. Great misdirection play.

## Notes:

# WR Cross

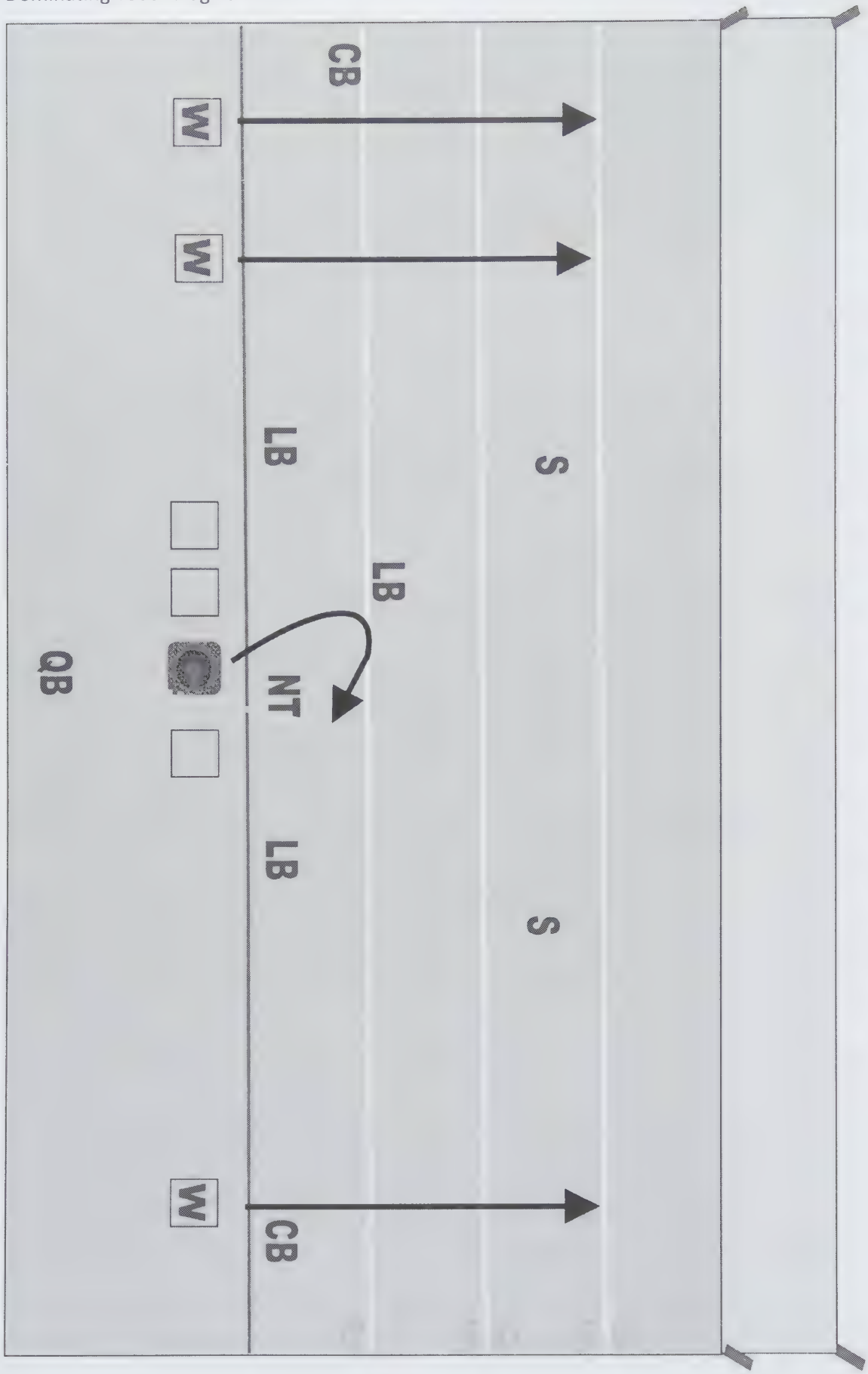


# WR Cross

We had to add this play after defenses figured out what we were doing and crowded the line of scrimmage. The outside receiver comes up and blocks the defender on the inside receiver. The inside receiver takes one step forward then heads out to the sideline. You can run it to either side, but remind them in the huddle which guy is blocking a defender and which guy is catching the ball.

# Notes:

# Line Release

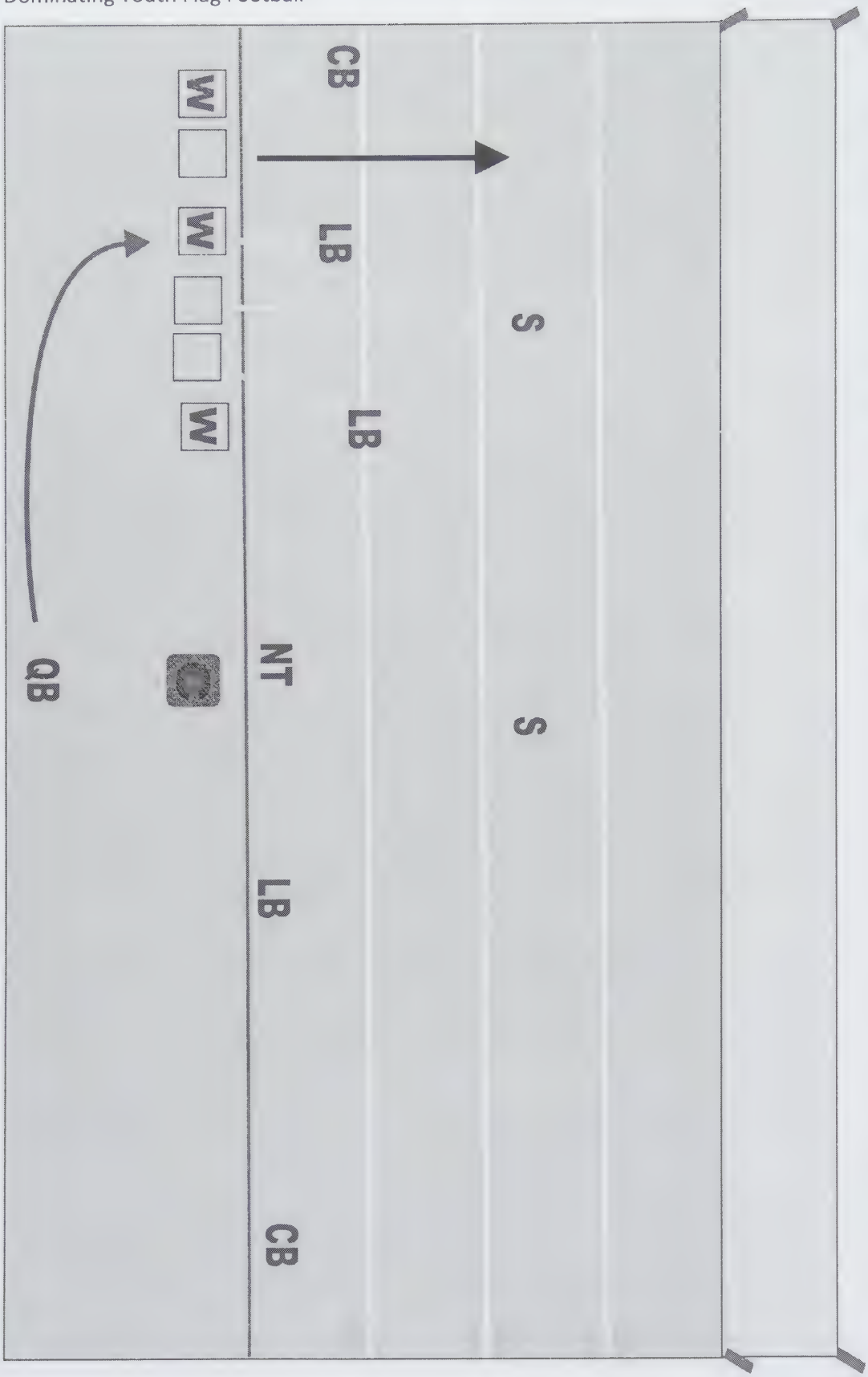


# Line Release

This is a quick hitting play when you need a quick five yards. The person snapping the ball to the quarterback let's his man through and turns around for a quick pass. Success rates depends on where they line up their linebackers. One missed flag pull, and you could easily have a 20 yard gain. Some leagues may not allow lineman to catch, but we have never encountered such rules. They almost always allow it, especially in adult leagues.

# Notes:

# All Side



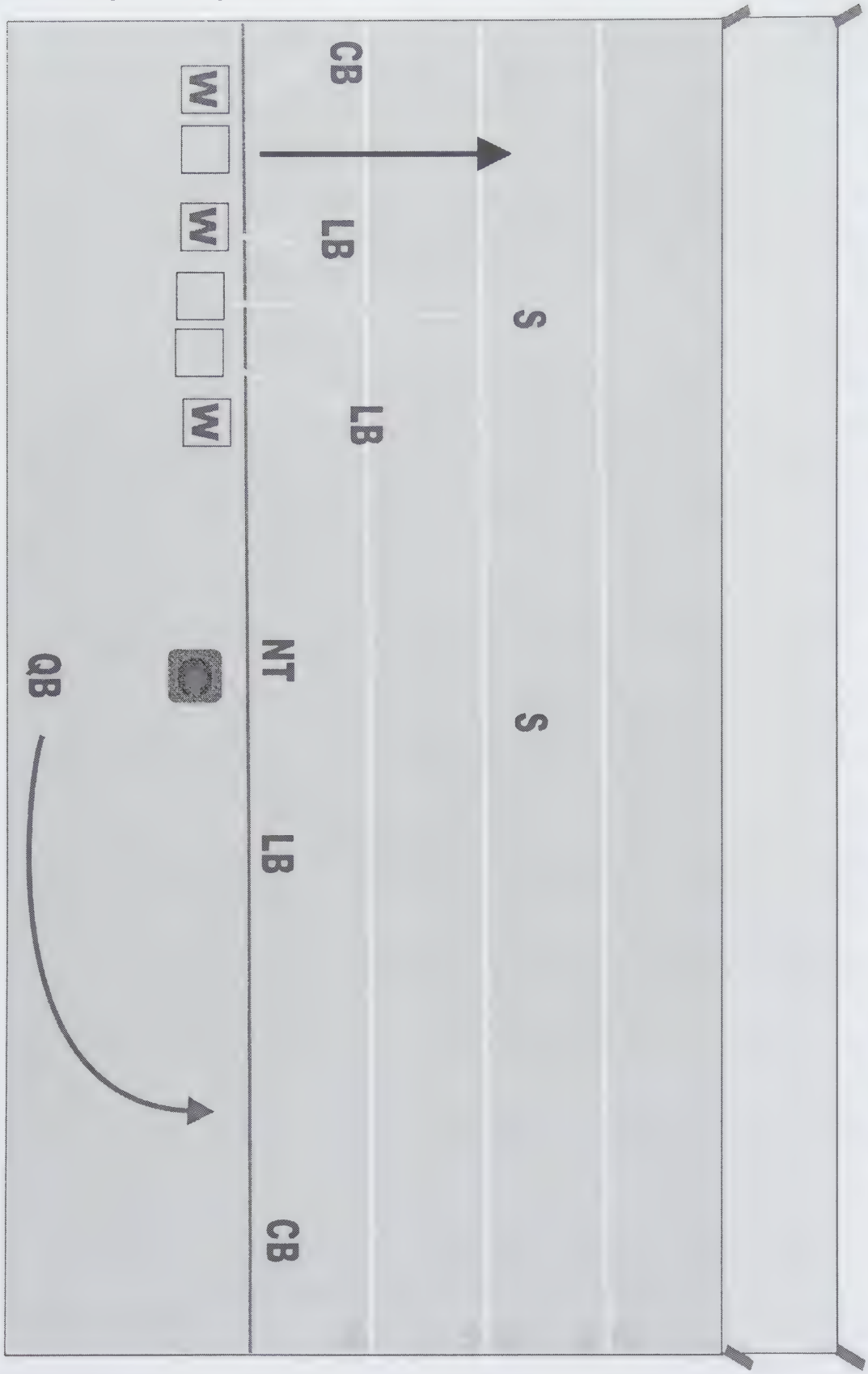
# All (to one) Side

This play is the quarterback sweep play, but you put all the players on one side. This may open up the opposite side if the coach sends all the defenders to the side where all your players are standing. The opposing coach may also just leave one guy on the open side. The first time you should run your quarterback to the side where all your players are standing. The players will run in front of him and block for him. Line up the same way on the very next play, the defense will think you are going to do the same thing again. But this time, your quarterback runs to the open side past one defender and gets a touchdown.

We teach the kids to each pick out a player they are blocking on this play by pointing to him and make sure no two kids are pointing at the same guy. The opposing defense may move the other outside linebacker over to the overloaded side, which still works, we have one more player to block him as well.

## Notes:

# All Side Naked



# All to one Side Naked Bootleg

You should run this play right after the All to one Side play. The defense is expecting the same play and will cheat over to that side. The quarterback gets the ball and quickly takes a step to the side where all the players are standing (left), then runs a sweep to the other side (right). That extra step, will buy more time as defenders start flowing to the left.

If you had run the Screen play prior to this, he can fake the screen then run to the other side. Runs these plays in succession to set up the defense for failure.

## Notes:

# Screen

# Screen

The players line up just like the "All to one side" play, but this time they all go out and block someone, one kid stays back and gets a quick screen pass. This will help slow down and stop the inside rush. The very next play quarterback can fake the screen pass and keep it and run the opposite way on a quarterback sweep. We teach the kids to each pick out a player they are blocking on this play by pointing to him and make sure no two kids are pointing at the same guy. The opposing defense may move the other outside linebacker over to the overloaded side, which still works, we have one more player to block him as well.

# Notes:

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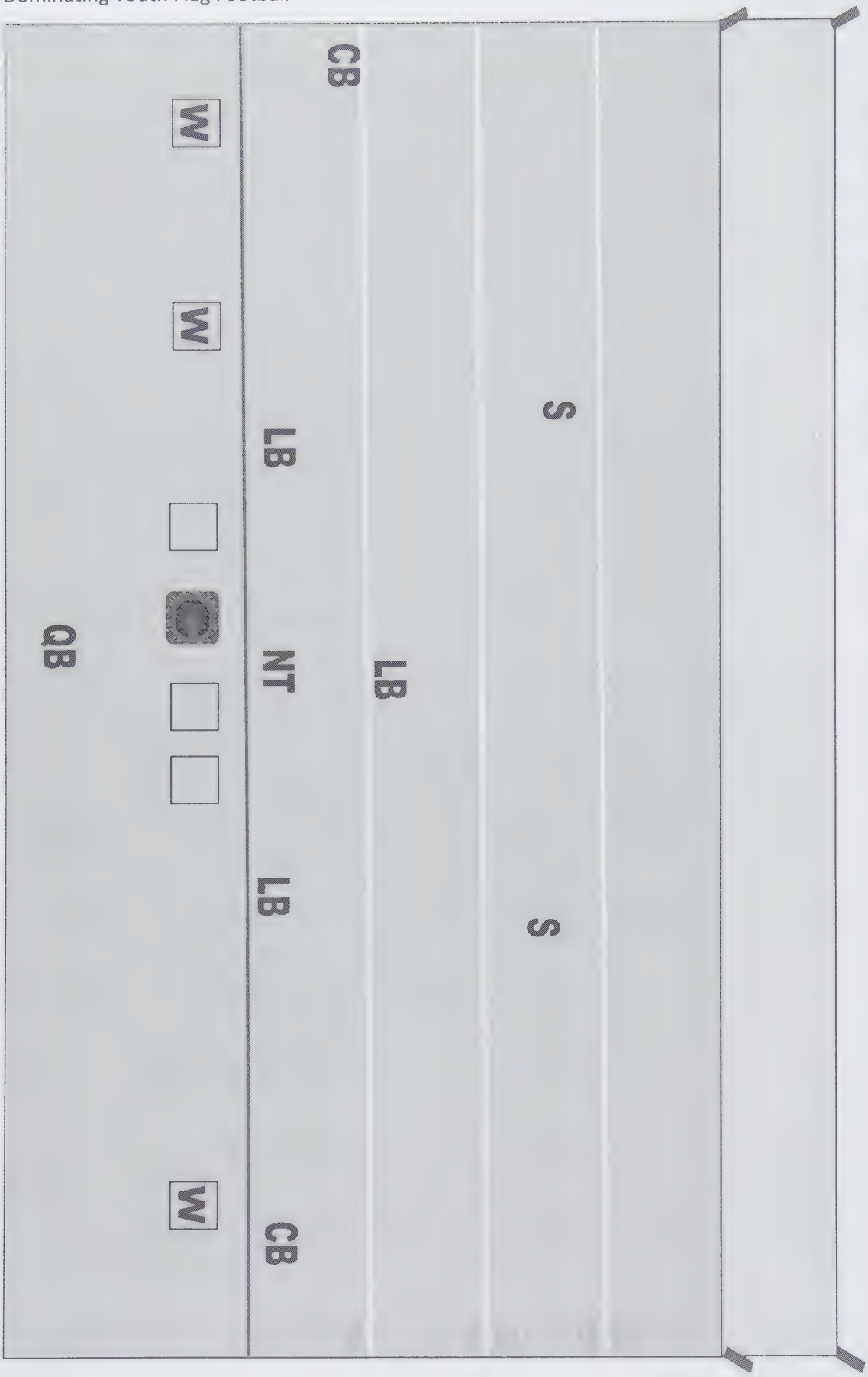
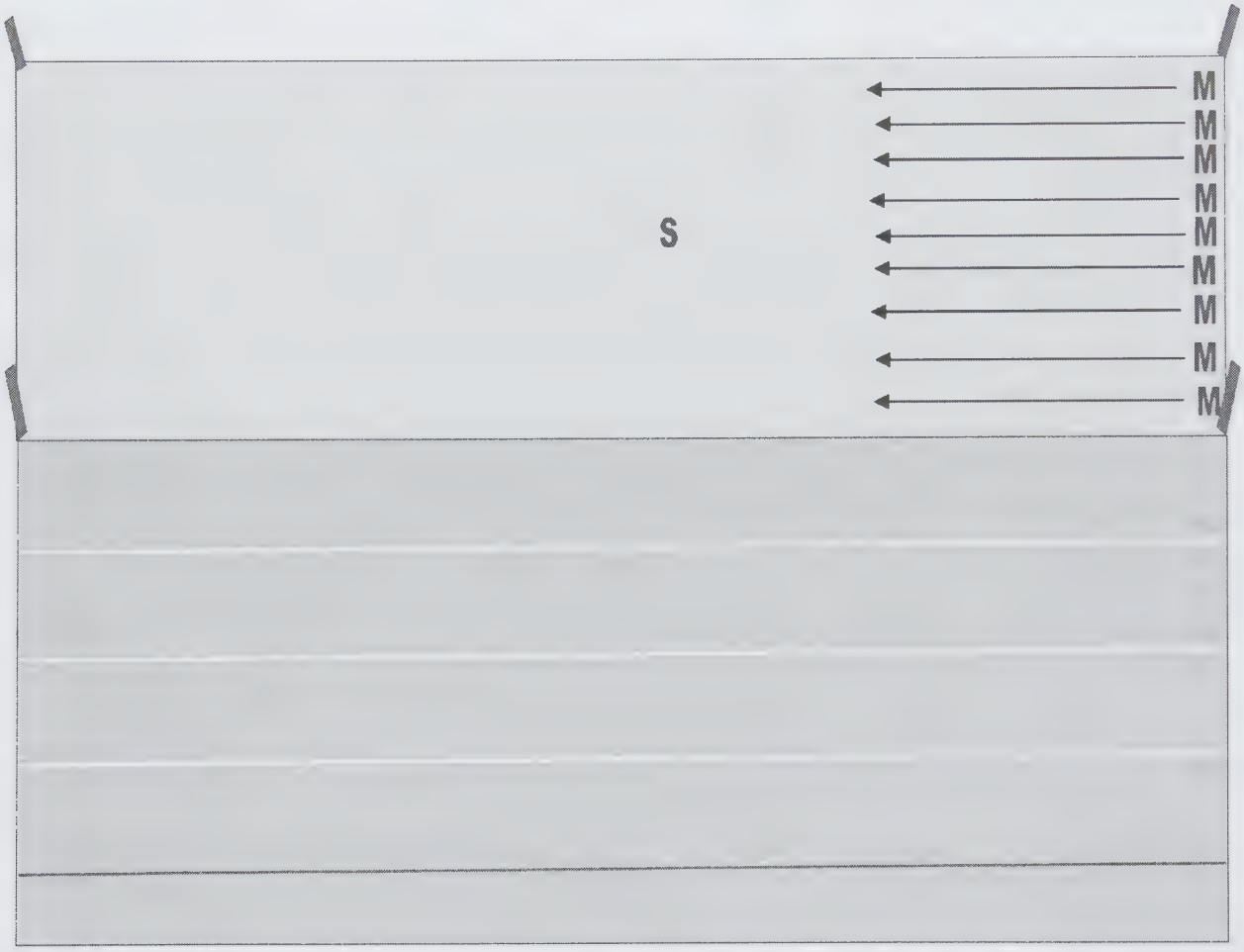


# Blank

These are all the plays you will need to cover almost any situation in flag football. Don't feel overwhelmed and try to teach them everything. In the first year, we only taught them the QB Sweep, End Around, Fake End Around, and QB Sneak. The other plays we saved for year two. We still won every game the first year. As the season goes on, you can introduce new plays. You don't need a pass play to win games, but if you have to have one the Drag play gives you a really nice run-pass option that can gain a lot of yards.

## Practicing pulling flags




We practice flag pulling one single way. It's a modified game of sharks and minnows. We take all the kids to the end zone and line them up in a line on the narrow side of the endzone. All the kids are standing in this narrow ten yard wide area. One kid starts out as the shark (S in the above picture) and is ten yards away from them. Everyone else is a minnow (All the Ms in the above picture). When the whistle is blown, their job is to get across to the other end of the end zone without going out of bounds and without having the flag pulled. We usually have two

parents on each sideline watching to see if any kids go out of bounds. The coach can stand anywhere and blows a whistle for them to run across. They keep going until there are no minnows left or one left and he wins the game.

This reinforces the "never go out of bounds" rule that we have. Every time they see a sideline, they cut back inside. This also teaches them incredible agility and juking skills. It also teaches them that you can run right by or through a guy and it's nearly impossible for him to pull your flag. We don't want them to try and juke too much, just run right by the guy.

## Don't put players in a bad position

If it's the end of the game and you are winning and want to put in some other players at quarterback because they have always wanted to play, try not to embarrass them. If they are not used to receiving a snap, have the normal quarterback receive it and give it to them. Although at this level most kids can easily receive the soft side snap, there will always be a kid on your team that can't. You will know since they all got to practice everything in practice. You will know which ones need help. This is the one exception to the rule of not having running backs. In this case, the additional kid in the backfield is a running back or second quarterback. When they get older and play tackle football, the snaps will come back hard and fast and then they really can't handle the snap. That's usually when this will come in handy. But most kids will be ok with the soft side snaps in flag football.

# Closing words

Coaching is very rewarding and tons of fun. Now you have more than enough information to get started in coaching and even to be very good. Remember that although these strategies were designed for younger kids, we have used them all the way up through adult leagues. It's the same basic concepts and strategies.

Go out and have fun and remember to keep it fun for the kids!

**If you want to contact Coach Alo or order this book at discounted rates in bulk, please visit:**

**http://CoachAlo.com**

**Most of our information is available for free at:**

**http://FootballTimes.org**

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